

VIKRAM SHARMA

"CHANDIGARH WILL REMAIN THE JOINT CAPITAL OF HARYANA AND PUNJAB. AAP SHOULD APOLOGISE TO THE PEOPLE OF HARYANA"

MANOHAR LAL KHATTAR
Haryana CM

"THE CENTRE MUST NOT TAKE ANY STEP THAT WILL DISTURB THE BALANCE OF THE ADMINISTRATION OF CHANDIGARH AND OTHER COMMON ASSETS"

BHAGWANT SINGH MANN
Punjab CM



the situation even more. In July 1986, with the Khalistan insurgency set to condemn Punjab to two fallow decades, the Union government suspended the transfer of land indefinitely.

Cut to the present, and you find Haryana chief minister Manohar Lal Khattar too wading into troubled waters with his aggressive stand on the Sutlej Yamuna Link (SYL) canal construction and sharing of river water. While Haryana has completed its side of the work (85 per cent of the total) on the canal, Punjab has not moved an inch in the past so many years. It continues to be defiant, despite an arbitration mechanism being in place. The new Mann government has also shown no interest in the issue so far. Water has been a particularly fraught and emotive issue for Punjab (indeed more so during the two decades of the Khalistan insurgency). Despite directions from the Centre, sundry tribunals and even the Supreme Court, Punjab has refused to share water with Haryana.

Mann, who is just starting his term in office, has little leeway since emotions in the state are already running high. There is still residual anger against the farm laws, stoked further by the BJP-controlled Centre's February 23 notification amending the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) Rules, 1974, and changing the criteria for the selection of full-time members. Board members can now be from across India, instead of just Punjab and Haryana. The BBMB was created as an autonomous board under the provisions of the Punjab Reorganisation Act to regulate the supply of water and power to Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Delhi and Chandigarh. The common belief is that the new rules will take away Punjab's control on the crucial dam headworks.

Water is a critical issue for both Khattar and Mann. Both states have stuck to their stand that depleting groundwater levels leave them with no choice in the matter. In Punjab, the water resource ministry data shows that 109 blocks out of 128 are in the 'dark zone' (severely depleted groundwater levels). Haryana needs the SYL water to irrigate farms in its southern parts. Officials here say groundwater levels in places like Gurugram district have fallen from a depth of 6.6 metres in 1976 to over 30 metres now. Haryana will not let go of Chandigarh even if it was inclined to unless Punjab relents on the water issue. The latter, meanwhile, says the water allocation system decided by the Balakrishna Eradi Tribunal in 1987—5 MAF (million acre-feet) water to Punjab and 3.83 MAF to Haryana—was faulty since it didn't consider Haryana's share of Yamuna water. Anyway, neither state had accepted these provisions and the dispute remains unresolved.

In 1960, after India signed the Indus Water Treaty with Pakistan, Punjab got use of the water from the tributaries. The 1966 reorganisation recommended water-sharing with drier Haryana. Punjab has three rivers—the Ravi, Sutlej and Beas—whereas Haryana gets water from the Yamuna. The SYL canal was planned as a 214 km conduit that would connect the Sutlej and Yamuna. But when construction started in 1982, political parties in Punjab cried foul and have resisted every move to complete the construction. In fact, in July 2004, the then Punjab chief minister Amarinder Singh convened a special assembly session and passed the Punjab Termination of Agreements Act, 2004, which abrogated all river water agreements with neighbouring states. In February 2017, the Supreme Court said Punjab would have to abide by its order on the SYL canal and it would pass a decree if the two states did not come to an agreement. Yet the SYL canal remains stuck, except for the occasional burst of political activity, like being raked up alongside the Chandigarh issue last week.

After the Aam Aadmi Party tsunami in the assembly election and with the general election due in 2024, political parties in Punjab are eyeing a consolidation. They need to be watchful, as an emotive issue like Chandigarh can stoke discontent in the state and have unpredictable repercussions. And that, for Punjab, would be a capital shame. ■